Chapter Three

A Nice State of Affairs, 1920

In a speech given to the Central Asiatic Society towards the end of 1920, Curzon – now fully foreign secretary [1] – declared that Britain 'must face the fact that the expansion of the British Empire in Central Asia is at an end, and rightly at an end'. The problem, however – as the Times newspaper saw it – was that while this fact was accepted readily by the British public, 'we are by no means sure that the Government are doing so, or even that Lord Curzon himself appreciates the full significance of his own words'. [2] The observation was telling, for, as this chapter will show, despite this pronouncement Curzon had spent most of 1920 categorically refusing to abandon his ambitions in South Asia or accepting the limitations that now existed on Britain's foreign relations. If the years 1918– 1919 had been a time of optimism for the British government – emerging as it did a victor of the First World War – the events of 1920 would soon bring an end to that feeling. The failure of the Anglo-Persian Agreement, the invasion of the Persian port of Enzeli by the Red Army, nationalist discontent in India, a restless Afghanistan and the possibility of a mass pan-Islamist movement across Asia all threatened to destabilise Britain's position in that part of the world in the post-war period. Quick to realise the potential of this popular discontent, the Soviet regime threatened to add to the explosive mix with the dissemination of anti-British, anti-imperialist propaganda throughout the region.

1920 was the year in which the forces of nationalism, pan-Islamism and Bolshevism would come to the fore of politics in South Asia. That such events coincided with (or marked) the military and political ascendancy of the Bolshevik regime within both Russia and Asia, compounded Britain's problems. Nonetheless, old habits die hard, and despite the arguments of the Indian government and the War Office, there were those in government who